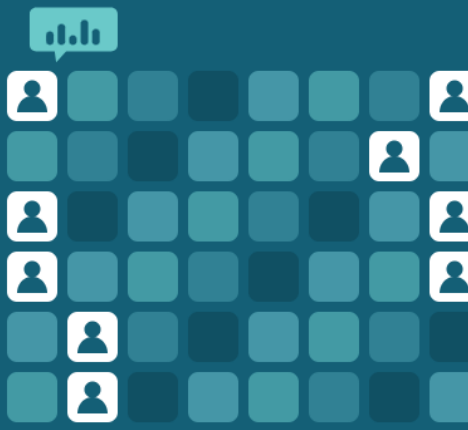
Place-based data training

Activities workbook

Module 2.1: Data discovery



This training brings together practical guidance for using data in place-based work. It draws on PLACE and Seer Data's work alongside place-based initiatives across Australia.

The training covers the journey many place-based initiatives go on – from finding and accessing data to sharing it, making sense of it with community and using it to support local decisions and action.

Who is it for?

It is designed for people working in or supporting place-based initiatives. You might be new to working with data or already using and managing data as part of your everyday rhythm.

How to use this workbook

Throughout the training, you'll find opportunities to reflect on your work and consider how the ideas and tools apply in your place or initiative. This workbook brings together the activities for this module.

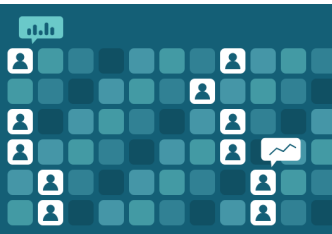
You can work through the training from beginning to end, or choose the modules most relevant to your role, experience and current work. We recommend starting with Welcome to place-based data training. You can return to other sections as you need them.

You can also connect with others doing the training to ask questions, share what you're learning and learn from their experience on PLACExCHANGE at **pxc.placeaustralia.org**.

A collaboration between

PLACE
Partnerships for Local Action & Community Empowerment

Seer
Data & Analytics



Community insights, data & stories

Module

2.1 Data discovery

Section 1	Find open data, and find who holds it	2 activities
Section 2	Read what the data is telling you	2 activities
Section 3	Run a data conversation everyone can join	2 activities

Try this now: find one dataset for your place

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Pick one of the five areas above, something live in your work right now. Open one source related to it from the Further reading list at the end of this module, and find your own local area. Then fill in the first three columns of the table below.

This table is the start of a data catalogue: each completed row is a line of a spreadsheet you could keep and grow after the module.

In the “One sentence this lets me say” column, write the single sentence this dataset lets you say about your place. Not a summary of the dataset: a sentence you could say out loud in a meeting. In the “What it does not show” column, write one thing this dataset misses about your place.

Title	Description	Source	One sentence this lets me say	What it does not show

Try this now: finish the record

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Go back to the dataset you found earlier and complete its record. Most of this information is on the same page you downloaded the data from. In the quality note, make a note of anything a colleague would want to know.

Custodian and contact	Geography	Time period	Update frequency	Format	Access rules	Quality note

> Record who the custodian is in their own right and who they share data with. This row is the start of a custodian map you can add to as you build your knowledge and relationships.

Custodian	What data they hold	Level (local, regional, state, national)	Role (creates, maintains, or only uses)	Who they share data with

> That is one complete catalogue entry and one custodian recorded. You now have a tool that you did not have before you started this section.
>
> Optional: If you have a question about a local issue and are looking for data to help build understanding, or you'd like to compare what you've found with others, why not start a conversation on the community board?

Try this now: name what you are looking at

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Go back to the dataset catalogue you developed in Section 1 and open its chart or table. Then work through the table below. Write down one thing you can see in it, and name which of the four it is: a shift, a gap, a pattern or a trend. If you would tick two, say which one you would lead with.

Note the period the data covers, then describe whether that timeframe is long enough to support what you just wrote. Finally, name the chart type that would show it best. Like the catalogue in Section 1, this row is a line of a reading log you could keep in a spreadsheet.

One thing I can see	Shift, gap, pattern or trend?	Timeframe the data covers	Is that long enough to support my claim?	Chart type that would show it best

> Tip: the word you choose matters. “Shift” says something moved. “Trend” says it is heading somewhere. Only the timeframe tells you which one you have.

Try this now: write the sentence that goes under the chart

Apply | Apply to your place 2

Take the finding you identified in the previous exercise and complete the table below. First, write the one-sentence key takeaway that would sit underneath the chart: plain language, no acronyms, no source citation in the sentence itself. Read it aloud, and if a sentence feels difficult to follow, try breaking it into smaller parts.

Then write one question you would ask a community member about it, using one of the three from above: does this reflect what you see? what stories sit behind this? what might be influencing this? Finally, name one person you could ask that question to this month.

The sentence that goes under the chart	One question I will ask a community member	One person I could ask this month

> You now have a finding, a sentence, a question and a person. That is a data conversation waiting to happen, which is what Section 3 is about.

Try this now: strip the jargon out of one sentence

Apply | Apply to your place 1

Find one sentence from your recent work: a report, an email, a funding application. Something with a technical term or an acronym in it. Write it in the first column. Then rewrite it for someone with no background in your sector: spell out every acronym, replace every technical word, and put a real number in a human shape, “one in five”, not “20%”.

In the last column, add the honest limitation: one clause naming what this information does not cover. Read the rewrite aloud, and if you run out of breath, cut it in half.

The sentence as it stands	The plain-language rewrite	The honest limitation

Try this now: plan one conversation

Apply Apply to your place 2

Use the finding, the sentence and the person you wrote down in Section 2, and fill in the plan below. Write the one question the session is built around: one question, not three. List the people and groups you will invite, using a stakeholder map so you catch informal leaders and trusted connectors, not only formal roles, and check that nobody who is affected has been left out.

Name a venue and time: somewhere people already go, at a time that suits them rather than you. Note the three things you will bring: which visual, which story or quote, and which way people will respond (sticky notes, a map to mark up, a wall chart).

Then write what you will do in the week afterwards to share back what you heard.

The one question the session is built around	Who I will invite	Venue and time	What I will bring: visual, story, way to respond	How I will share back what I heard

Facilitator's checklist

A facilitator's checklist takes you through the rest, ten checks across the life of the session.

Before the session – plan with intention

- [ ] Map the voices you need in the room
- [ ] Design for cultural safety
- [ ] Prepare inclusive materials

During the session – facilitate with respect

- [ ] Set the tone early
- [ ] Encourage participation
- [ ] Use flexible creative formats
- [ ] Listen deeply

After the session – reflect and share back

- [ ] Capture what you heard
- [ ] Share back and follow through
- [ ] Reflect and learn